



THE
ZSMC CO
ESTD 2026



Founding Charter

Document ID: ZSMC-GOV-001 Rev 0

Effective Date: 16-08-2026

To conduct rigorous, accessible, and independently minded research and to develop scientific and technological knowledge through reproducible investigation, engineering experimentation, computational research, and open intellectual inquiry.

The ZSMC Co. was founded as an independent research initiative dedicated to conducting, supporting, and communicating rigorous scientific and technical research.

The organisation exists to pursue research questions that are considered worthwhile on the basis of their scientific, technological, or societal significance, while maintaining a deliberate emphasis on reproducibility, transparent methodology, responsible experimentation, and honest reporting of both successful and unsuccessful results.

The ZSMC Co. recognizes that scientific credibility is established through evidence, reproducibility, critical examination, and independent scrutiny rather than through institutional prestige, financial scale, or promotional claims.

Accordingly, this Charter establishes the foundational identity, principles, governance, and responsibilities of The ZSMC Co. and provides the basis for the policies, agreements, and procedures adopted under it.

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Article I – Identity and Nature

The organisation shall be known as The ZSMC Co., hereafter referred to as “ZSMC” or “the Organization”.

ZSMC is an independent research initiative operating from India. ZSMC is organized around research activity rather than commercial product development as its primary institutional purpose.

Nothing in this Charter shall be interpreted as asserting that ZSMC possess a particular statutory, corporate, charitable, tax, or nonprofit legal status unless and until such status has been formally established under applicable law.

ZSMC shall maintain intellectual independence in the selection, conduct, interpretation, and communication of research, subject to applicable agreements, funding conditions, safety requirements, and law.

External funding, collaboration, affiliation, sponsorship, or partnership shall not by itself determine scientific conclusions.

ZSMC shall maintain consistent institutional identification across its research outputs and scholarly activities.

Where appropriate, ZSMC may maintain and use persistent organizational identifiers, including ROR and other recognized scholarly identifiers.

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Article II – Mission

The mission of The ZSMC Co. is:

To conduct rigorous, accessible, and independently minded research and to develop scientific and technological knowledge through reproducible investigation, engineering experimentation, computational research, and open intellectual inquiry.

ZSMC shall seek to:

1. investigate scientifically meaningful questions;
2. develop and test technological concepts;
3. encourage rigorous independent research;
4. support researchers working across disciplinary boundaries;
5. make appropriate research outputs accessible and reproducible;
6. communicate research honestly and clearly;
7. encourage collaboration between independent researchers and established institutions;
8. develop practical technologies where supported by credible evidence; and
9. contribute useful knowledge to the broader scientific and technical community.

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Article III – Research Principles

All research conducted under the ZSMC affiliation shall be guided by the following principles:

Honesty - Research shall be represented accurately. ZSMC shall not knowingly fabricate, falsify, manipulate, or selectively misrepresent research findings.

Reproducibility - Where reasonably possible, research shall be documented sufficiently for another competent researcher to understand and reproduce the relevant methodology.

Transparency - Researchers shall distinguish clearly between established findings; experimental observations; modeled or simulated results; hypotheses; assumptions; preliminary results; and future objectives.

Intellectual Humility - Researchers shall acknowledge uncertainty, limitations, failed experiments, contradictory evidence, and alternative explanations where relevant.

Responsible Communication - Public communications shall not deliberately exaggerate the significance, maturity, safety, performance, or certainty of research findings.

Correction - When a material error is discovered in a ZSMC research output, the Organization shall seek to correct the public record appropriately.

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Article IV – Research Areas

ZSMC may conduct interdisciplinary research across scientific, technological, engineering, mathematical, computational, and related fields where such research is consistent with its mission, available expertise, resources, safety requirements, and applicable law.

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Article V – Organisational Structure

ZSMC shall maintain an organizational structure appropriate to the scale and nature of its research activities.

The Organization may include:

1. Founder / Organizational Lead
2. Researchers
3. Research Advisors
4. Project Leads
5. Administrative or technical personnel, where required

Titles shall reflect actual responsibilities and shall not be used solely to imply qualifications, authority, or institutional status that an individual does not possess.

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Article VI – Founder and Institutional Authority

The founder of ZSMC is Srijal Dutta. The founder shall serve as the principal organisational authority responsible for maintaining the institutional mission; establishing research programs; approving institutional policies; appointing researchers and advisors; approving major collaborations; overseeing institutional resources; maintaining organisational records; representing ZSMC where appropriate; and ensuring that institutional activities remain consistent with this Charter.

The Founder may delegate operational responsibilities without permanently transferring ultimate institutional authority unless such transfer is formally established through an amendment or successor governance arrangement.

The Founder shall remain subject to the same standards of research integrity and responsible conduct applicable to other researchers.

The Founder may establish a successor governance arrangement through formal amendment to this Charter. Any such arrangement shall specify the authority, responsibilities, and effective date of the successor structure.

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Article VII – Researchers and Affiliates

1. Research Affiliation

Individuals may conduct research under the ZSMC affiliation only when their relationship with the Organization has been formally recognized.

2. External Researchers

ZSMC may accept researchers who are not employees, officers, or permanent members of the Organization. External researchers may participate in defined research projects while retaining their independent academic, professional, or institutional affiliations.

3. No Automatic Transfer of Existing Work

Affiliation with ZSMC shall not, by itself, transfer ownership of a researcher's pre-existing intellectual property to ZSMC.

Pre-existing intellectual property shall be governed by applicable agreements and declarations made at the commencement of the relevant research relationship.

4. Project-Based Participation

Where an external researcher substantially contributes to a ZSMC-originated research project, the Organization shall establish the relevant rights, responsibilities, publication arrangements, and intellectual-property arrangements through an appropriate written agreement.

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5. Academic Credit

Academic credit, authorship, inventorship, acknowledgment, and intellectual-property ownership are separate matters.

Research contributors shall receive appropriate academic credit based on their actual intellectual and research contributions and applicable disciplinary standards.

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Article VIII – Intellectual Property

ZSMC shall maintain a separate Intellectual Property Framework governing research outputs.

The framework shall distinguish at minimum between:

1. **Background IP** — intellectual property originating independently of a ZSMC project or relationship;
2. **ZSMC-originated Project IP** — intellectual property arising from research initiated, organized, funded, or materially supported by ZSMC;
3. **Jointly developed IP** — intellectual property created through contributions from multiple parties; and
4. **Third-party IP** — intellectual property owned or controlled by parties outside ZSMC.

ZSMC shall not claim ownership of an individual's unrelated research merely because that individual is affiliated with the Organization.

Project-specific intellectual-property rights shall be established through written agreements.

Where applicable, such agreements may provide ZSMC with defined exclusive or non-exclusive rights for a specified period while preserving legally required inventorship, authorship, attribution, and other rights.

No provision of an internal ZSMC policy shall override mandatory requirements of applicable intellectual-property law.

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Article IX – Publication and Academic Credit

ZSMC shall encourage publication and dissemination of legitimate research findings.

Publication decisions shall consider:

- scientific quality;
- research integrity;
- authorship and contribution;
- confidentiality;
- intellectual-property protection;
- applicable agreements;
- safety;
- legal obligations; and
- the interests of collaborators and research participants where applicable.

Researchers shall not be denied appropriate authorship merely because intellectual-property rights are held by another party.

Conversely, institutional affiliation shall not itself constitute authorship.

Authorship shall be determined according to actual intellectual contribution and applicable scholarly standards.

Before public disclosure of potentially patentable or otherwise protectable research, a reasonable intellectual-property review may be conducted in accordance with the applicable project agreement.

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Article X – Research Integrity

ZSMC shall maintain Research Integrity addressing, at minimum:

- fabrication;
- falsification;
- plagiarism;
- inappropriate manipulation of data;
- inappropriate authorship;
- undisclosed conflicts of interest;
- improper attribution;
- research recordkeeping;
- correction of errors;
- responsible use of computational tools;
- responsible use of artificial intelligence; and
- procedures for reporting and addressing suspected misconduct.

Research misconduct shall be treated as a serious institutional matter.

The Organization shall seek to investigate credible concerns fairly and proportionately while avoiding retaliation against individuals who raise good-faith concerns.

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Article XI – Data and Research Records

Research conducted under ZSMC shall be documented through appropriate research records.

Depending on the project, records may include:

- laboratory notebooks;
- experimental records;
- source code;
- computational environments;
- datasets;
- analysis scripts;
- instrument records;
- photographs;
- calibration records;
- sample identifiers;
- project decisions; and
- research reports.

Researchers shall make reasonable efforts to preserve sufficient information to establish the provenance of significant research results.

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Article XII – Safety

ZSMC shall treat researcher and public safety as a fundamental requirement of research activity.

Research involving chemicals, electrical systems, electrochemical cells, laboratory equipment, biological materials, hazardous substances, specialized machinery, or other potentially hazardous activities shall be conducted only within appropriate safety arrangements.

Where research is conducted in a school, university, laboratory, makerspace, or other external facility, the rules and safety requirements of that facility shall apply.

ZSMC policies shall not be interpreted as granting permission to perform activities prohibited by a host facility or applicable law.

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Article XIII – Funding and Resources

ZSMC may receive grants, donations, sponsorships, research support, equipment, services, or other resources consistent with its mission and applicable law.

Funding shall not justify falsification, suppression, or deliberate distortion of research findings.

Material financial or other conflicts of interest shall be disclosed and managed appropriately.

The use and allocation of research resources shall be documented sufficiently to maintain institutional accountability.

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Article XIV – Collaborations

ZSMC may collaborate with:

- researchers;
- universities;
- schools;
- laboratories;
- companies;
- nonprofit organizations;
- research organizations;
- governmental institutions; and
- other appropriate entities.

Significant collaborations shall be governed by written agreements where appropriate.

Such agreements should address, as applicable:

- scope of work;
- responsibilities;
- publication;
- authorship;
- confidentiality;
- intellectual property;
- data;
- funding;
- safety;
- termination; and
- dispute resolution.

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Article XV – Research Projects

Each substantial ZSMC research project should have a documented project identity.

Where appropriate, a project record shall specify:

- title;
- research question;
- project lead;
- participating researchers;
- objectives;
- methodology;
- expected outputs;
- safety considerations;
- data arrangements;
- intellectual-property arrangements;
- publication arrangements; and
- project status.

Research projects may be exploratory, theoretical, computational, experimental, developmental, or interdisciplinary.

Project status shall accurately reflect its actual stage of development.

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Article XVI – Institutional Records

ZSMC shall maintain an institutional record of significant organizational documents, including:

- this Charter;
- amendments;
- policies;
- researcher affiliations;
- project records;
- collaboration agreements;
- intellectual-property agreements;
- significant funding records;
- publication records; and
- major institutional decisions.

Public and confidential records shall be maintained separately where necessary.

Sensitive personal information, confidential agreements, unpublished intellectual property, and other restricted information shall not be publicly disclosed merely for the purpose of demonstrating institutional activity.

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Article XVII – Institutional Transparency

ZSMC shall maintain a public institutional presence sufficient to allow external researchers and members of the public to understand:

- what ZSMC is;
- who conducts research under its affiliation;
- what research it undertakes;
- which outputs are published;
- which projects are ongoing;
- what claims are established versus preliminary; and
- how external researchers may contact or collaborate with the Organization.

Public information shall be maintained accurately and corrected when materially outdated or erroneous.

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Article XVIII – External Review and Accountability

ZSMC recognizes external criticism and independent review as essential components of scientific progress.

The Organization may seek:

- peer review;
- independent technical review;
- experimental replication;
- external characterization;
- advisory review;
- conference presentation; and
- other appropriate forms of external evaluation.

External review shall not be represented as peer review, certification, validation, or endorsement unless it actually constitutes such a process.

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Article XIX – Research Events and Scientific Community

ZSMC may organize or host:

- conferences;
- symposia;
- seminars;
- workshops;
- research discussions;
- demonstrations; and
- other scientific or technical events.

Events organized by ZSMC shall accurately represent their nature, participating organizations, speakers, and level of review or selection.

The organization of an event shall not itself imply that the participating speakers endorse all ZSMC research.

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Article XX – Institutional Affiliations

Researchers may maintain affiliations with ZSMC alongside affiliations with schools, universities, companies, laboratories, or other organizations, subject to the requirements of those institutions.

Researchers shall not represent ZSMC as having institutional relationships that have not actually been established.

Likewise, ZSMC shall not represent an individual as being affiliated with the Organization beyond the scope and duration of their actual relationship.

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Article XXI – Amendments

This Charter may be amended when necessary to reflect:

- organizational growth;
- changes in governance;
- legal requirements;
- research activities;
- institutional partnerships; or
- other significant developments.

Amendments shall:

1. receive formal approval by the authorized institutional authority;
2. receive a new version number;
3. record an effective date;
4. preserve a record of previous versions; and
5. not retroactively alter contractual rights unless the affected parties agree or applicable law permits such alteration.

Minor editorial corrections that do not alter substantive meaning may be recorded without constituting a substantive amendment.

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Article XXII – Interpretation

Where a conflict exists between this Charter and applicable law, applicable law shall prevail.

Where a conflict exists between this Charter and a specific written contractual agreement, the parties' legally enforceable contractual obligations shall govern the relevant relationship to the extent permitted by law.

Where a conflict exists between this Charter and a detailed ZSMC policy, this Charter shall prevail unless the Charter expressly delegates authority to the relevant policy.

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Article XXIII – Institutional Continuity

The Organization shall maintain continuity of research records, intellectual-property records, publications, and significant institutional documentation regardless of changes in individual researchers or organizational personnel.

Departure of a researcher shall not, by itself, invalidate previously published research or erase legitimate academic credit.

Rights and obligations concerning intellectual property, confidentiality, data, publications, and research records shall survive termination to the extent established by applicable agreements or law.

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Article XXIV – Foundational Statement

The ZSMC Co. is established on the principle that a research organization earns its credibility through the quality, transparency, reproducibility, and usefulness of the work it produces.

Institutional status, awards, funding, identifiers, partnerships, publications, and public recognition shall be treated as means of supporting research rather than substitutes for research quality.

ZSMC therefore commits itself to the following principle:

Evidence before prestige. Reproducibility before publicity. Intellectual contribution before title. Scientific honesty before institutional interest.

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Adoption

This founding charter is adopted as the foundational governance document of The ZSMC Co.

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